

The Fracture

Most people don't have a system. They have advisors who don't connect.

RUSS MICHAELS · APRIL 2026 · 4 MIN READ

A founder I know had seven conversations in a single week.

Monday was his attorney. Tuesday, his CFO. Wednesday, an executive coach. Thursday, his estate planner. Friday, his trainer. Saturday, a couples therapist. Sunday, nothing — because there was nothing left.

Each one was good. Competent. Credentialed. Paid well to be exactly what they were. None of them spoke to each other.

The attorney didn't know how the capital decisions were actually being made. The CFO didn't know what the pressure at home felt like. The coach didn't understand the legal exposure sitting underneath the strategy. The estate plan had no relationship to the life it was meant to protect.

Seven people. Seven clean domains. One life, moving through all of them.

From the outside, it looks like support. From the inside, it feels like drift. Nothing is technically wrong. And yet nothing quite holds.

The cost doesn't show up in a single mistake. It accumulates in the gaps — between conversations, between decisions, between versions of the same person.

This isn't a coordination problem. It isn't solved by better meetings or tighter summaries or another layer of management over the advisors. It's a worldview problem.

Every profession involved is built to see a slice. Law isolates risk. Finance isolates capital. Coaching isolates behavior. Health isolates the body. Relationships get their own lane, as if they don't sit underneath all of it.

That structure makes sense if a human being is modular. It doesn't make sense if they're not.

A serious person — someone carrying real decisions and real consequence — is not a set of independent systems. The legal, the financial, the physical, the relational, the long-term: all of it

is one system, whether the people around them treat it that way or not.

The industry fragments because the providers are fragmented. Not because the human is.

And the burden of integration falls back on the person with the least slack to carry it.

WHERE THIS CAME FROM

I didn't arrive at this as a theory.

I spent a decade as a transaction attorney, closing over \$350M in equity across real estate and operating businesses. Hundreds of deals, each one a different configuration of risk, personalities, incentives, and time pressure. In the same decade, I was building companies — as a CEO, as an operator, as an advisor inside other people's capital structures and decisions.

Alongside all of that, there was another track. Breathwork. Yoga. Nonviolent communication. Men's work. Martial arts. Not as hobbies, but as the practices that determine whether someone can actually hold the pressure they're asking for.

Because at a certain level, the work isn't just technical.

You can structure a deal correctly and still have it fail because of how someone shows up inside it. You can optimize capital and degrade the life it was meant to support. You can build something that works on paper and doesn't hold under stress.

The integration wasn't a strategy. It was a requirement. There isn't a clean line between the person making the decision and the decision itself.

WHAT VAULT HUMAN IS

Vault Human came out of that — not as a concept, but as a response to a constraint: people doing serious work eventually run out of margin for fragmented support.

It's a private firm built around that reality. Four practices sit under one roof — law, executive coaching, systems and AI, and development and capital advisory — with legacy treated as an active practice rather than a document. They aren't sold as separate products. They're applied as parts of the same system, with a single point of view about how they interact.

What makes the firm different isn't the services. None of them are novel in isolation. What's different is that they aren't held by separate people with separate incentives and partial visibility. They're held by someone who has operated inside each of those domains and has a position on how they fit — when to prioritize structure over speed, when to slow a decision down because

of what's happening outside the deal, when something that looks efficient is actually creating downstream fragility.

The point is that the work is integrated at the level it actually lives.

IF YOU'VE FELT IT

If you've operated at that level for any length of time, none of this is surprising. You've already felt the gaps. You've already had the moment where the advice was technically right and contextually wrong — where something broke, not because no one was competent, but because no one had the whole picture.

Most people accept that as the cost of doing business. It isn't. It's a structural failure that hasn't been named clearly enough.

For the people who can see it, the question isn't whether the system is fractured. It's how long you're willing to keep carrying the weight of holding it together yourself.

— **Russ Michaels** · Founder, Vault Human · www.vaulthuman.com/writing